



Pupils stand outside their classroom at Almossat Primary School for Girls in Madeinat locality, Gedaref state, Sudan. Previously, girls in Madeinat endured long and tedious walks of 2 -3 km to the nearest girls' school, crossing the main town and a busy market.

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Spotlight on the Global Gender Equality Thematic Fund 2024



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UNICEF works across 12 of the 17 Sustainable Development Goals (SDGs) to bring positive change for children. The Global Gender Equality Thematic Fund makes vital contributions to SDG 5: Gender equality and the empowerment of all girls and women.

1. UNICEF's Global Gender Equality Thematic Fund: Building a foundation for every child's future

Gender equality is not only a fundamental right; it is a powerful driver of progress. When girls and women are empowered to access education, health care, protection and economic opportunities, entire communities benefit. Yet structural inequalities, harmful social norms and chronic underfunding continue to hold back millions of girls and women around the world.

UNICEF is working to change that, not only through targeted programmes but by transforming the systems that shape gender equality outcomes in every part of a child's life. Guided by the Gender Action Plan 2022–2025, UNICEF's work spans health, education, protection, climate resilience and social protection to ensure that girls and women in all their diversity can survive, thrive and lead. The impact is real and offers hope for a more equitable future.

At the heart of this effort is the Global Gender Equality Thematic Fund, UNICEF's most strategic vehicle for advancing gender equality at scale. Its flexible, multi-year design allows UNICEF to respond to urgent needs, scale up what works and strengthen the systems that deliver lasting impact.

The value is clear: every dollar invested in gender-responsive programming for adolescent girls yields more than four times the return through gains in health, education and productivity, and reduced costs of inaction.¹ These investments do not just change lives; they transform futures.

¹ United Nations Children's Fund 'Right on the Money: Making the Case for Rights-Based Investments in Adolescent Girls', UNICEF, New York, 2024, <www.unicef.org/media/163431/file/en-brief-right-on-money-2024.pdf.pdf>.

"Gender equality is not just a goal, it is a game-changer. Thanks to our partners, UNICEF is advancing one of the most transformative investments we can make in children, communities and shared progress. Your support is helping unlock a more just and inclusive future for all."

Kitty van der Heijden, Deputy Executive Director, Partnerships, UNICEF

Gender equality is not an 'add-on'. It is a foundation for development, for resilience and for every child's right to a safe, healthy and empowered life.

2. Financial results

Investment catalysing progress for generations

The most powerful progress in gender equality is built not just on time-bound programmes but on systems that last. UNICEF and its partners are creating more inclusive, equitable and resilient futures for girls and women.

In 2024, the Global Gender Equality Thematic Fund mobilized US\$5.1 million in contributions from committed private and public partners. UNICEF extends sincere thanks

to the governments of Germany, Luxembourg, Iceland and Canada and private sector partners Clé de Peau Beauté, Chloé, Max Factor, Sylvamo and others who contributed to the Fund, including through National Committees. Their generous support has been crucial for UNICEF's gender equality programmes and high-impact initiatives around adolescent girls.

These contributions are not just closing gaps – they are sparking change, empowering girls, shifting social norms and strengthening the systems that uphold the rights of women and girls now and for generations to come.

Top Global Gender Equality Thematic Fund partners by contributions received, 2024²

Sector	Donor	Amount (US\$)
Public	Germany	1,648,478
	Luxembourg	605,548
	Iceland	200,000
	Canada	43,575
Private	United States Fund for UNICEF	965,906
	UNICEF Country Office PSFR	651,186
	French Committee for UNICEF	308,776
	United Kingdom Committee for UNICEF	198,353
	Hong Kong Committee for UNICEF	140,000
	Dutch Committee for UNICEF	98,902
	Japan Committee for UNICEF	92,727
	German Committee for UNICEF	30,000
	Italian Committee for UNICEF – Foundation Onlus	20,000
	UNICEF Philippines Country Office PSFR	20,000
	Spanish Committee for UNICEF	20,000
	UNICEF Indonesia Country Office PSFR	15,000
	UNICEF Viet Nam Country Office PSFR	10,000
	Korean Committee for UNICEF	10,000
	Canadian UNICEF Committee	10,000
	UNICEF Malaysia Country Office PSFR	10,000
	UNICEF Thailand Country Office PSFR	10,000
Grand Total		5,108,451

Note: Numbers may not add up due to rounding. PSFR: Private sector fundraising.

² The thematic funding contributions relate to the Strategic Plan 2022–2025.



Wearing helmets, Saifu (left), Issahak (middle) and Fusioni (right) stand in their welding workshop at Walewale Technical Institute, in the town of Walewale in North-East Region, Ghana.

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Why flexible funding matters

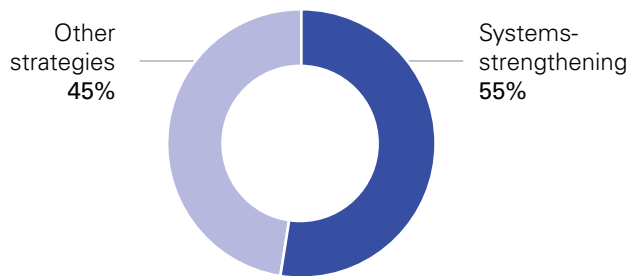
The Global Gender Equality Thematic Fund is not just a funding stream; it is a catalyst for lasting change. Its flexible, multi-year support over the four-year period of UNICEF’s Strategic Plan (2022–2025) enables UNICEF to align with country priorities, respond swiftly to emerging challenges and invest in the systems that uphold the rights of girls and women.

In 2024, UNICEF incurred US\$2.8 million in flexible funding expense from the Gender Equality Thematic Fund. These investments helped reduce prevalence of child marriage and female genital mutilation, empower adolescent girls, and advance gender equality across health, education, protection and climate resilience.

This funding is a cornerstone of UNICEF’s Gender Action Plan (2022–2025). It enables long-term planning and adaptive programming, which are especially crucial in underfunded areas and humanitarian settings, where rigid, short-term funding cannot meet evolving needs.

When received at the global level, flexible funding becomes a powerful tool for equity. It reaches the most marginalized girls, strengthens public systems and scales proven solutions. Every flexible dollar moves UNICEF closer to a world where all girls and women can survive, thrive and lead.

UNICEF expense by programme strategy, 2024



In 2024, 55 per cent of Gender Equality thematic funding was spent on strengthening systems that uphold the rights of girls and women.

Note: The category ‘other’ consists of strategies which enable systems-strengthening, including advocacy and communications; social and behaviour change; data and research; digital transformation; innovation; partnerships and engagement; and support to programme delivery.

A call to scale: What works

Achieving SDG 5: Gender equality is not a distant goal – it is an urgent global imperative. Progress requires more than stand-alone programmes. It demands a deep shift towards strengthening the systems that uphold the rights of girls and women, challenge inequality and expand opportunity in every setting.

The Global Gender Equality Thematic Fund is UNICEF’s most strategic mechanism for driving that change. It enables countries to scale what works, invest in inclusive systems, and dismantle the social and structural barriers that hold girls and women back.

These investments go beyond short-term impact. They embed gender equality into the core of health, education, protection, social policy and climate systems, creating lasting pathways for girls and women to grow up safe, healthy and empowered to shape their futures.

We invite more partners to stand with us. Together, we can accelerate progress, scale solutions and build a world where every girl has the freedom, opportunity and support to reach her full potential.



Transparency with Thematic Funding

UNICEF has a strong financial transparency record, including for thematic funding. We encourage UNICEF partners to the Global Gender Equality Thematic Fund to visit the Transparency Portal and access real-time information on spending in the countries receiving funds.

3. The footprint of the Global Gender Equality Thematic Fund

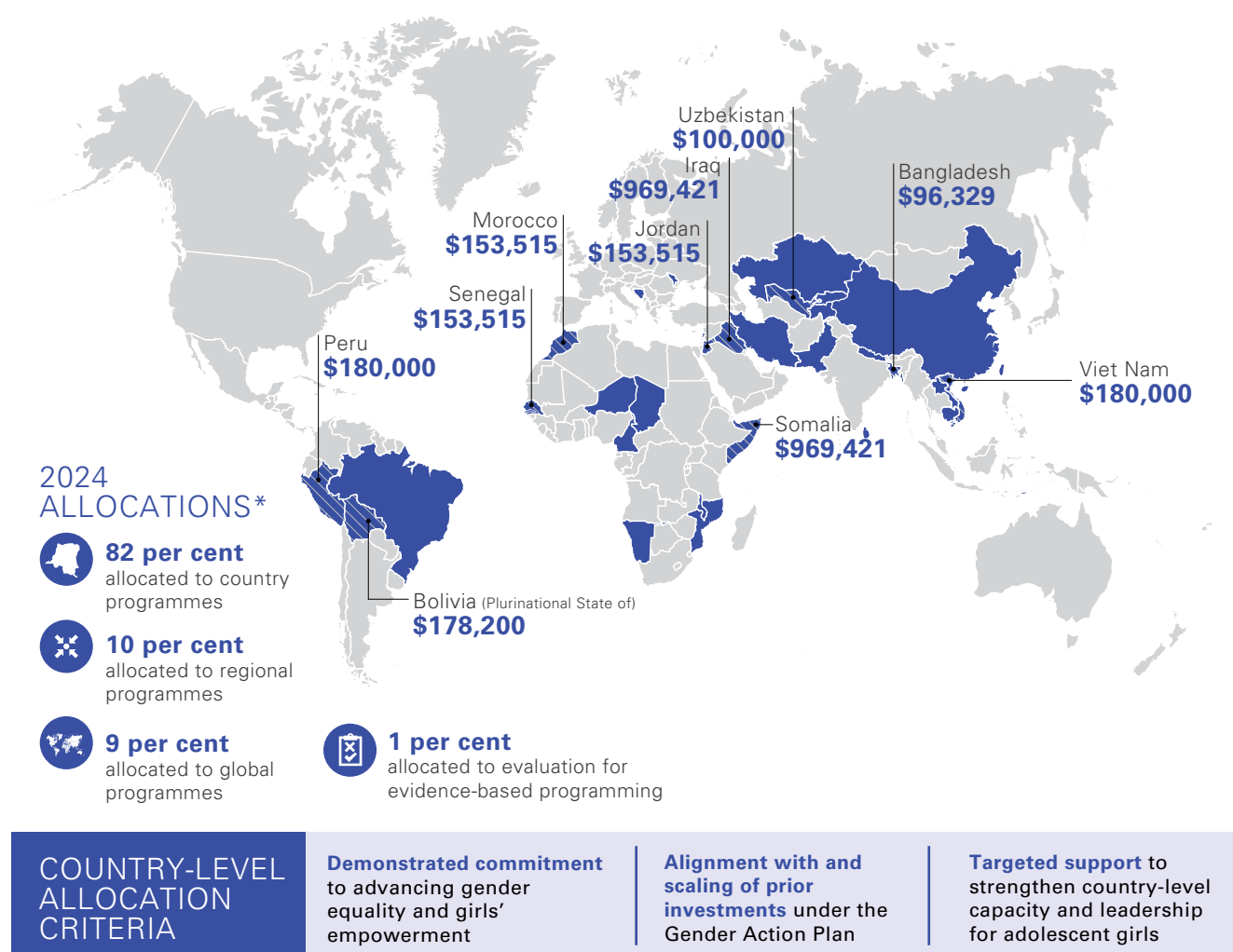
The Global Gender Equality Thematic Fund enables UNICEF to deliver impact for girls and women across every region, through coordinated investments at three levels:

- At the **country level**: Investments support national efforts to empower adolescent girls, equip them with skills, prevent harmful practices and advance gender equality in education, health, protection and climate resilience.
- At the **regional level**: Investments strengthen technical expertise and foster collaboration to scale proven, context-sensitive strategies.

- At the **global level**: Investments support UNICEF's technical leadership in pioneering global tools, guidance and communities of practice to embed gender equality across all programming for children.

Each level reinforces the others, helping shift systems, shift power and shift outcomes for girls to grow up safe, healthy and empowered to lead.

Global Gender Equality Thematic Fund allocations around the world³



Note: The map is stylized and not to scale. It does not reflect a position by UNICEF on the legal status of any country or area or the delimitation of any frontiers.

³ The map shows all countries that received allocations from the Gender Equality Thematic Fund between 2022 and 2024. The 10 highest allocations in 2024 are shown with full amounts.

4. From programmes to policy: A systems shift for gender equality

Gender inequalities are vast, but UNICEF's response is equally bold. Across every region, UNICEF is driving a shift from fragmented interventions to strong, integrated systems that place gender equality at the core of every child's right to survive and thrive.

UNICEF's systems-strengthening model is anchored in workforce development, policy and legislative reform, social and behaviour change, data and evidence, infrastructure for service delivery and sustainable financing – and proven in delivering measurable and holistic results.

In 2024, flexible thematic funding enabled UNICEF to deliver transformative results by dismantling structural barriers, shifting harmful norms, and empowering girls and women across both development and humanitarian settings.

This work is not about short-term change. It is about building the systems, leadership and social consensus that ensure girls and women are safe, valued and able to lead not just now, but for generations to come.

Below are some headline sector results for which Global Gender Equality thematic funding, as part of a broader portfolio of funding, was a key contributor.

Legal and policy change

Achieving gender equality starts with changing the rules that shape opportunity. UNICEF works with governments and civil society to draft national policies, revise legislation and mobilize public budgets, ensuring the rights of girls and women are protected not just in practice, but in law.

- In the **Gambia**, UNICEF with UNFPA supported civil society organizations and faith-based organizations to advocate against efforts to reverse the ban on female genital mutilation. The law was successfully upheld in 2024, and FGM remains criminalized in the Gambia.

UNICEF also works to improve policies that promote inclusive access to essential services, removing the barriers that hold girls back from reaching their full potential.

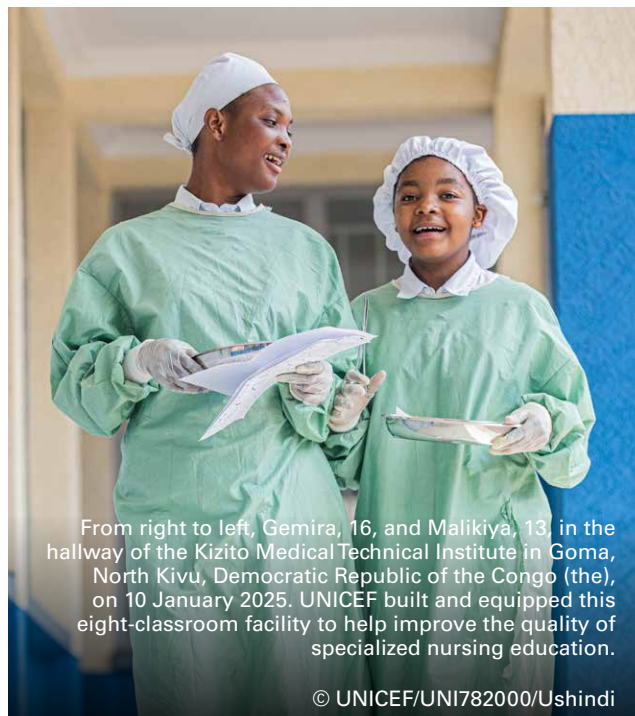
- In **Brazil**, UNICEF empowered **690 adolescent girls** across 8 Brazilian cities, building their leadership and advocacy skills to influence policymaking. As 'agents of change' they have collectively secured commitments from local policymakers on issues such as menstrual dignity, public safety and gender-based violence, and reached **4,650 adolescents** with information and support through peer education.

Workforce development

At the heart of every resilient system are the dedicated front-line workers, most of them women, who deliver essential services and life-saving information, often in remote areas and during crises. Through its multisectoral approach, UNICEF is investing in this critical workforce, ensuring that those on the front lines are trained, equipped and empowered to advance gender equality and transform lives.

Country-level investments brought these global frameworks to life:

- In **Morocco**, UNICEF's cross-sectoral programming helped reduce school dropout rates by **3.2 per cent** across six districts. Local partners trained front-line workers on gender equality, supported girl-led advocacy, and engaged adolescent girls in research and skills-building that advanced learning, leadership and empowerment.
- In **China**, UNICEF strengthened science, technology, engineering and mathematics (STEM) education for girls in rural areas, training teachers in gender-sensitive pedagogy and creating inclusive learning materials. Science camps sparked interest in technology and innovation for over **374,000 girls** in remote communities.



From right to left, Gemira, 16, and Malikiya, 13, in the hallway of the Kizito Medical Technical Institute in Goma, North Kivu, Democratic Republic of the Congo (the), on 10 January 2025. UNICEF built and equipped this eight-classroom facility to help improve the quality of specialized nursing education.

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Students participate in a Meena Raju Manch session focused on gender awareness and play-based learning at Zilla Parishad Primary School in Arni village, Dharashiv District, Maharashtra, India.

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- In **Viet Nam**, more gender-responsive education has benefited nearly **137,000 adolescent girls** to date. UNICEF interventions have improved the knowledge and skills of over **450 teachers** in inclusive STEM, student career orientation and bilingual education to support **30,000 students** – 51 per cent of them girls, including from ethnic minority groups. National STEM events promoted girls' leadership in science and technology, engaging more than **4,200 students**. These efforts fostered cultural sensitivity, reduced gender stereotypes and expanded equitable career pathways.

Infrastructure for service delivery

Strong infrastructure is the backbone of gender equality. Around the world, women and girls are disproportionately impacted by inadequate access to basic services, from social protection to clean water, safe sanitation and inclusive learning environments. These gaps affect health, dignity, mobility and opportunity. UNICEF plays a vital role in keeping these systems running and ensuring they serve every girl, everywhere.

In 2024, UNICEF delivered measurable progress in expanding gender-responsive infrastructure across critical sectors:

- UNICEF introduced and expanded girl-focused programmes (designed with and for adolescent girls) in 63 countries, aligned with the Adolescent Girl Programme Strategy. These dynamic, girl-centred initiatives reached over **30 million girls** in 2024, driving measurable change in empowerment, well-being and leadership.

The Global Gender Equality Thematic Fund made targeted impact at country level:

- In **Iraq**, UNICEF helped scale up social protection coverage to **550 vulnerable adolescent mothers** by expanding the 'girl-centred cash-plus model', which is addressing poverty through cash transfers and enabling access to integrated health services.
- In **Jordan**, in partnership with the Ministry of Digital Economy and Entrepreneurship and local community-based organizations, UNICEF launched a digital skills programme targeting vulnerable youth, especially girls. Around **120 adolescents and youth** (65 per cent female, 40 per cent refugees) were equipped with market-relevant skills such as programming, data analytics, graphic design and digital marketing. As a result, **42 youth** – 80 per cent of them young women – secured freelance or creative digital jobs.
- In **Peru**, more than **260 adolescent girls** participating in the Skills4Girls initiative gained access to hands-on training in web programming and project-based learning. Mentoring and family engagement strengthened the girls' confidence and established a strong support system, with 95 per cent reporting satisfaction on completion of the course.
- In the **Niger**, following political instability in 2023, UNICEF launched a pilot digital learning programme for displaced girls in Niamey and surrounding areas.
- **200 out-of-school girls and boys** received learning support from qualified teachers in addition to support with temporary learning spaces and digital tablets.

- **40 vulnerable girls** were given a second chance in learning through school re-enrolment. With additional support, 67.5 per cent passed their lower secondary exams – nearly double the national average. The girls also gained access to digital and computer literacy training.
- **250 leaders and 350 young people** were engaged in the promotion of extracurricular activities and delivering peer support to empower girls.
- **1 million people** were reached through community engagement activities on the promotion of girls' rights.
- In **Senegal**, in coordination with the Ministry of Education, UNICEF empowered **100 vulnerable adolescents** (79 per cent girls) aged 10–14 with cutting-edge digital, leadership and entrepreneurial skills through participation in a six-day boot camp focused on robotics, leadership and personal development.

Data, evidence and financing for gender equality

Robust data are the foundation of meaningful gender equality progress. They inform policy, guide funding and ensure that resources reach the girls and women who need them most. Data and evidence are what turn good intentions into real-world results – enabling governments to design targeted interventions, track progress and improve accountability.

In 2024, UNICEF deepened its investment in data systems and evidence generation to advance more equitable outcomes for girls and women across sectors. Key milestones included:

- In partnership with the **University of Cape Town, the University of Oxford and the University of the Witwatersrand**, UNICEF produced 'Right on the Money', a policy brief demonstrating the powerful economic returns of investing in adolescent girls through targeted, gender-responsive interventions. The findings show that smart investments in girls are not only morally right but economically sound, and are supporting advocacy efforts globally.
- Through the **Spring for Impact** initiative, in-depth research and documentation efforts have helped identify innovative methods and tools for capturing the results of adolescent girl empowerment projects – improving how results are measured and strengthening the planning and development of girl empowerment programmes.

- In **Somalia**, UNICEF supported a formative study across three districts to understand the diet-related norms and behaviours of adolescent girls. The evidence generated helped inform new, locally tailored social and behaviour change action plans – increasing access to iron folate supplementation and expanding efforts to prevent gender-based violence.
- In **Cameroon**, a gender barrier analysis was conducted on vaccination and vitamin A supplementation, helping to inform planning and programme delivery to improve health outcomes for girls.

When data drive action, equity accelerates. Through sustained support for research, monitoring and financing strategies, UNICEF is working to ensure every girl and woman has the opportunity to survive, thrive and lead.

Results that last

Systems-strengthening is a long-term investment, but one with transformative returns. In 2024, Global Gender Equality thematic funding, as part of a broader portfolio of funds, was a powerful catalyst to dismantle barriers, ensure equal access to services, and create environments where gender equality is not only encouraged but sustained.

- In **66 countries**, UNICEF challenged discriminatory norms that drive harmful practices and perpetuate inequality.
- **27.6 million people** were engaged in community dialogues – shifting attitudes, reshaping expectations and building momentum for change.
- **6.4 million adolescent girls** in 20 countries gained access to quality learning opportunities, building their confidence, digital fluency and employability to succeed in the 21st-century workforce through the Skills4Girls initiative.

These are not just numbers – they are lives improved, futures protected, and systems made stronger for generations to come.



Scan the QR code or click on the image to read UNICEF's Data Companion and Scorecard for more information on progress against SDG and Strategic Plan targets. Thematic Funding as part of UNICEF's overall funding portfolio contributes to this progress.

5. Impact story

Powering the future: Girls leading Bolivia's green and digital transformation

Imagine a world where every girl is empowered to innovate, lead, and transform her community. In Bolivia (Plurinational State of), this vision is becoming a reality, thanks to UNICEF's ground-breaking Global Gender Equality Thematic Fund.

Bolivia's high-altitude Andean region offers immense potential for harnessing solar and wind power. Yet the country's energy mix remains heavily reliant on thermal sources such as natural gas and diesel, with minimal investment in alternative energies. Given this vast renewable energy potential, digital and green skills are of vital importance. However, a deep-rooted divide persists between girls and boys in STEM, with only 30 per cent of university students being women.

UNICEF's response is transformative. Through innovative partnerships and the Skills4Girls initiative, in 2024, UNICEF empowered over 670,000 girls and young women to lead Bolivia's transition to a sustainable energy future. Key pillars of this initiative include:

- **Rewriting the rulebook:** Collaborating with government agencies to create policies that support girls in STEM and green energy sectors, and securing sustainable investments to ensure long-term impact
- **Empowering the front lines:** Training a network of female mentors in digital and green technologies and implementing hands-on learning experiences that link digital skills to climate action
- **Girls leading the charge:** Launching girl-led innovation projects and community-based solutions, and training young women to become leaders in STEM and climate action
- **A united front:** Coordinating a multisectoral approach to integrate digital and green skills into education and community services, and partnering with universities, the private sector and women's organizations to support girls' transition into STEM careers.



Mary, 15, is the 2024 champion of the national robotics tournament FIRST Bolivia. She won the gold medal in the category of disruptive inventors thanks to her prototype Pacha Uma, a robotic boat made of totora reeds to collect rubbish from Lake Titicaca.

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At the heart of this initiative are powerful stories of innovation and impact. Yessica, a participant from a rural community, invented an automated pod irrigation system to support small-scale farming and increase food production in areas where water scarcity is a serious challenge.

"Life here is very difficult due to the lack of water, but this mainly happens because we base our production on rain. So, I started thinking about how I can help my community," she explained.

Her invention uses a humidity sensor to deliver water precisely to plants when needed, optimizing resources and boosting yields – a shining example of UNICEF's commitment to empowering girls in STEM and green energy.

Your investment, their future: Your investment in this initiative is a declaration that every girl deserves the chance to thrive, to be heard, and to shape her own future. With your support, we can create a generation of empowered young women, capable of learning, innovating, and contributing positively to their communities.

Over 20 countries are now engaged in girl-centered initiatives in STEAM, digital and green fields. In 2024, UNICEF's global Skills4Girls initiative reached 6.4 million adolescent girls with the skills and opportunities they need to join the 21st-century workforce.

6. Hearing from our donors and partners

Clé de Peau Beauté: Empowering girls for a brighter future



Since 2019, global luxury skincare and make-up brand Clé de Peau Beauté, part of the Shiseido Company Limited, has partnered with UNICEF to support global efforts to advance gender equality and girls' empowerment. Through a global cause-related marketing campaign, the partnership focuses on creating opportunities for adolescent girls through STEM education, skills development and protection initiatives. A portion of the sales from Clé de Peau Beauté's best-selling The Serum contribute to programmes in specific countries, as well as the Global Gender Equality Thematic Fund. This catalytic support empowers UNICEF to break down barriers for girls worldwide by expanding access to quality education and STEM training, challenging harmful gender norms through community-driven change, reinforcing protection systems against violence, exploitation and discrimination, and advocating for gender-responsive policies at every level.

Beauty with purpose: Investing in the next generation

Clé de Peau Beauté believes that 'radiance' comes from within, and that the key to a better world lies in unlocking the power of girls through education and opportunity. Its partnership with UNICEF reflects a shared vision of unlocking girls' potential as future leaders, innovators and change-makers.

"Our partnership with UNICEF is rooted in the belief that when girls are educated and empowered, they transform their lives and their families, communities and societies. Through this partnership, we are proud to support initiatives that give every girl the opportunity to shine." – Mizuki Hashimoto, Chief Brand Officer, Clé de Peau Beauté

Clé de Peau Beauté's long-standing commitment to UNICEF is helping to forge a world where every girl can realize her fundamental right to learn, lead and thrive.

Iceland and UNICEF: Championing gender equality through bold investment

UNICEF deeply values Iceland's pioneering leadership in advancing gender equality through systems-strengthening investments. As one of the first public donors to UNICEF's Global Gender Equality Thematic Fund, Iceland's catalytic support – now doubled to ISK 50 million annually through 2028 – is transforming opportunities for girls worldwide by embedding gender action across education, protection and leadership systems.

"The Icelandic government is proud to be involved in these important projects. Gender equality and the empowerment and education of girls are key issues in development cooperation and the progress of societies." – Martin Eyjólfsson, State Secretary of the Ministry for Foreign Affairs of Iceland

This strategic funding accelerates high-impact initiatives globally, reaching youths and girls with programmes on STEM, prevention of gender-based violence, and vocational and leadership development for refugee girls, while driving gender-responsive legislation, policies and inclusive water, sanitation and hygiene (WASH) and health infrastructure. By strengthening key systems to address underlying causes of gender inequality, Iceland's investment is creating a ripple effect that transforms entire communities – ensuring girls today become the change-makers of tomorrow.

"At a time of widespread cuts across the aid sector, Iceland's increased contribution is a vital show of leadership and solidarity. It is helping drive real results for girls and sends a powerful signal about what matters most." – Kitty van der Heijden, UNICEF Deputy Executive Director



Mampi, 16 years old, 9th grade class, is sewing a sanitary pad, Mali.

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